

30 Minutes Expert PC goes to Boot camp

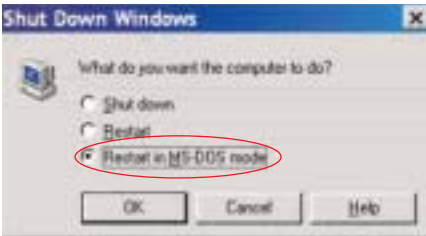
The eXtended Operating System Loader (XOSL, available at www.xosl.org) is a boot manager that you can use to select between multiple OSes and other boot devices during system start-up. It is completely free to use, has an easy to use, graphical interface and can boot into practically any OS on the planet. Although there are other tools associated with it such as the Ranish Partition Manager and SBM, the Smart Boot Manager, this article will show you how to setup and best use XOSL.

Remember to keep a bootable floppy or a bootable CDROM handy. In case things mess up after you install XOSL, and you cannot boot into your OS, boot into a DOS prompt and type FDISK /MBR.

XOSL can either sit on its own partition or on the Master Boot Record (MBR) of your hard disk. If you wish to give it its own partition, ensure that you tag it as an active one. We will give it the MBR, since it is the simpler of the two options. We will also assume that you have Windows 98 as the primary OS, with Windows 2000 or XP forming the second OS. Note that you can also boot into a Linux distribution using XOSL. Right then, lets get our hands dirty.

Installation: Extract the ZIP file found on the Mindware CD on to a temporary directory. The package consists of two directories: Manual and XOSL. You can take it two ways from here: either copy the contents of the XOSL directory onto a bootable floppy; or reboot into MSDOS mode and take it from there. We will take the second option, so restart the PC in MSDOS mode and head for the XOSL directory.

Note that, in case your primary OS is Windows 2000 or XP, you should go the

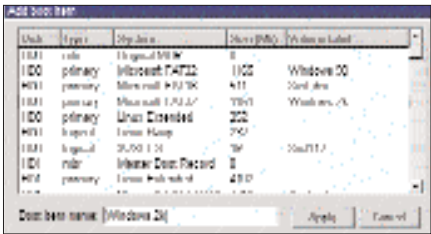


Restart in MSDOS mode to install XOSL

bootable floppy route, install from there and keep the floppy in a safe place for future use.

Setting it up: Type 'install' at the command line to start the process up. XOSL will analyse your system for the partitions available, your mouse type and the maximum resolution that your monitor can support. Click on the first option (Install on a DOS drive), note that you can change the Video mode and the drive you wish to install to, amongst other things. Make sure that there is a Yes for the Ranish partition manager and the SMB. Choose Start installation, press [Enter], press [Y] and when it asks to install SBM, press [Enter]. Press any key to install XOSL onto your system, press the Reboot button.

POST it: After the POST, XOSL will throw an initial screen at you. This is where you configure it to boot your OSes. Click on the Setup button to do this, then hit the Add button to bring up a menu of partitions that reside on your hard disk(s). Since we are multi-booting a Windows 98 and a Windows 2000 partition, we will make the selections as seen in the screenshot. Note that HD0 is

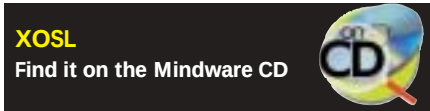


Choose the partition that you wish to boot from, here we select Windows 2000 and 98 OSes located on the first hard disk, HD0

your first hard drive, HD1 the second, and so on. Give appropriate names to your boot partitions and click on Apply. This will create two boot items.

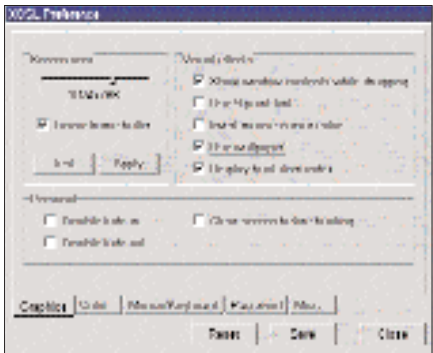
Choose the partition that you wish to boot from, here we select the Windows 2000 and the Windows 98 OSes located on the first hard disk—HD0.

The Ranish Partition Manager can be called from the XOSL screen by pressing [Ctrl]+[P]. Proceed with extreme caution.



Make sure you have backed up your data before you use Ranish.

Did you know: XOSL is very configurable. You can assign a password to a boot item for greater security by clicking on the Password tab. You can also assign each boot item a Boot key from within the Keys tab. Click on the Save button, then on Close. This will take you to the main window. Here you can click on Preference to change the resolution, to give Visual effects (such as adding a wallpaper to the



The Graphics tab lets you change the resolution or wallpaper amongst other things

boot menu), changing the UI colours, assigning shortcut keys, etc. Change the options as you see fit, click on Save and then on Close. Select the OS of choice, and then click on Boot to start the operating system. That's it, you are done!

The Graphics tab allows you to change the resolution or use wallpaper amongst other things. To password protect your boot-up, head for the Password tab, shortcut keys to common tasks can be found and changed from the Misc tab

The manual directory where you unzipped XOSL contains additional help and guidelines to get the best from XOSL. We recommend reading the contents of the CD ROM and the install sub-directories in particular.

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